

# The Causes of World War I

History, Year 9, Unit 2: The Great War

# Learning objectives

- Identify the long-term causes of World War I
- Explain how the assassination in Sarajevo started the war
- Judge which cause was most important

# Europe in 1914

- The great powers: Britain, France, Germany, Russia, Austria-Hungary
- Competing for land, trade and influence
- Long-term tensions had been building for decades

# Remember MAIN

## **M: Militarism**

Building up armed forces

## **A: Alliances**

Promises to defend each other

## **I: Imperialism**

Competition for empires

## **N: Nationalism**

Strong pride in your nation

# Militarism

- Armies grew quickly in the years before 1914
- Naval race: Britain and Germany built huge battleships called dreadnoughts
- Leaders trusted military power to solve problems

# War plans

- Countries prepared detailed plans for war
- Germany's Schlieffen Plan: defeat France quickly, then turn to Russia
- The plan meant marching through neutral Belgium

# Alliances

## **Triple Alliance**

Germany  
Austria-Hungary  
Italy

## **Triple Entente**

France  
Russia  
Britain

A war between two countries could pull in all their partners.

# Imperialism

- Empires meant wealth, raw materials and status
- Britain and France had the largest empires
- Germany wanted colonies too, causing rivalry in Africa and Asia

# Nationalism

- Strong pride in your nation, sometimes believing it is better than others
- Made many people eager to support a war
- Slavic groups like the Serbs wanted freedom from Austria-Hungary

# The Balkans: "the powder keg of Europe"

- Serbia wanted to unite Slavic peoples
- Austria-Hungary saw this as a threat to its empire
- Russia supported Serbia

# Sarajevo, 28 June 1914

- Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to Austria-Hungary, visits Sarajevo
- He is shot by Gavrilo Princip, a young Bosnian Serb
- Princip was helped by a secret Serbian nationalist group, the Black Hand
- Austria-Hungary blames Serbia

# From one shot to a world war

- 28 July** Austria-Hungary declares war on Serbia
- 30 July** Russia mobilizes to protect Serbia
- 1 August** Germany declares war on Russia
- 3 August** Germany declares war on France
- 4 August** Germany invades Belgium; Britain declares war

# Summary

## **Long-term causes**

Militarism, alliances, imperialism, nationalism

## **Short-term cause**

The assassination of Franz Ferdinand

# Discussion

Which cause was the most important? Use evidence to explain your answer.